

Medicines during disrupted services

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep essential medicines, a written medication list and the supplies needed to administer them accessible. Follow each product's storage instructions and protect medicines from floodwater, freezing and excess heat. Contact a pharmacist or clinician for a product-specific shortage or storage problem; do not change doses or substitute medicines on your own.

Do now.

- ☐ **Write the essential list**
01 Record the medicine name, strength, usual dose, prescriber, pharmacy and allergies. Keep a paper copy with the medicine and a copy with a trusted contact.
- ☐ **Count usable supply**
02 Track what remains and identify which medicine interruption is most urgent. Include inhalers, needles, testing supplies and batteries, not just tablets.
- ☐ **Protect storage**
03 Use the product label and pharmacist advice for temperature limits. Avoid direct heat and sunlight; do not let temperature-sensitive medicines freeze against ice packs.
- ☐ **Contact alternatives early**
04 Try a reachable pharmacy, clinician or verified medical aid provider before the supply is exhausted. Ask about the exact product; replacement rules vary.
- ☐ **Keep treatment unchanged unless advised**
05 Do not ration by skipping or doubling doses without professional direction. Seek urgent medical help for deterioration rather than trying an unverified substitute.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the written list to seek qualified advice through a reachable pharmacy or verified clinic. Preserve safe storage and track supply. If a life-critical treatment cannot be maintained, prioritise relocation to care before the last dose or battery is used.

Watch for.

A medicine can be unsafe after heat or flood exposure even when its package looks normal. Product-specific advice matters; there is no universal safe unrefrigerated storage period.

People & practical needs.

Write names, strengths, schedules, allergies, prescriber and pharmacy contacts and any storage needs. Keep that information private and accessible to a trusted caregiver. Include supplies needed to administer the medicine, not only the package itself.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Before a disruption, agree a refill and storage plan with the prescriber or pharmacist, within local rules. If you use insulin or powered equipment, keep its specific emergency instructions with the kit.

Check the next usable option

Before a disruption, agree a refill and storage plan with the prescriber or pharmacist, within local rules. If you use insulin or powered equipment, keep its specific emergency instructions with the kit.

When the first option is unavailable

Use the written list to seek qualified advice through a reachable pharmacy or verified clinic. Preserve safe storage and track supply. If a life-critical treatment cannot be maintained, prioritise relocation to care before the last dose or battery is used.

Questions in the field.

Can a warm medicine still be used?

Storage limits depend on the exact product and whether it has been opened. Record the name, time and temperature if known and contact a pharmacist or clinician. Do not apply a generic insulin rule to every medicine or throw away an essential supply without checking safe replacement options.

What if the usual pharmacy is closed?

Keep the current prescription and medication list ready and seek a reachable licensed pharmacy or care team. Verify the source before accepting donated medicine. Do not change doses, share prescriptions or use unverified substitutes to extend supply.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

FDA · Keeping medications safe in emergencies

<https://www.fda.gov/drugs/fda-drug-info-rounds-video/emergency-preparedness-keeping-medications-safe-feb-2016>

CDC · Diabetes care during emergencies

<https://www.cdc.gov/diabetes/articles/diabetes-care-emergencies.html>

FDA – Insulin storage during an emergency

<https://www.fda.gov/drugs/emergency-preparedness-drugs/information-regarding-insulin-storage-and-switching-between-products-emergency>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/medication-continuity/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.